

Hygiene with limited water

FIELD SKILLS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Reserve safe water for drinking, food, medicines and essential hygiene. Wash hands with safe water and soap before food preparation and after toilet or waste handling. Keep clean and dirty tasks separate. Sanitiser with at least 60% alcohol helps when hands are not visibly dirty; it does not remove chemicals or replace washing dirty hands.

Do now.

- ☐ **Set up a clean station**
01 Put safe water, soap and a clean towel or air-drying arrangement near food and care tasks. Use a container that does not require everyone to dip dirty hands into the supply.
- ☐ **Prioritise key washing times**
02 Wash after toilet and waste handling, before eating or preparing food and before wound or infant care. Do not use suspected chemically contaminated water on skin.
- ☐ **Use sanitiser appropriately**
03 Use at least 60% alcohol sanitiser when soap and safe water are unavailable and hands are not visibly dirty. Keep it away from flames and children.
- ☐ **Separate waste and food**
04 Store rubbish and toilet waste away from water, food and sleeping areas. Clean high-contact surfaces using product instructions without mixing chemicals.
- ☐ **Plan personal care**
05 Include menstrual supplies, nappies, necessary skin care and clean clothing. Keep wounds clean and covered; worsening redness, pain or fever needs medical assessment.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use the smallest workable clean-water station and protect it from contamination. Reduce nonessential washing before cutting drinking water or essential handwashing.

Watch for.

Surface disinfectant is not drinking-water treatment. Do not apply household bleach to skin or mix bleach with ammonia or other cleaners.

People & practical needs.

Make the hygiene plan usable for children, mobility needs and caregivers changing diapers or handling wounds. Keep gloves, cleaning tools and drinking-water supplies distinct

Next decision.

Replenish safe water when a verified source becomes available. Keep a routine that the household can sustain; a simple clean station is more useful than occasional improvised deep cleaning.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

CDC · Personal hygiene during an emergency

CDC · Emergency water

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/guides/emergency-hygiene/>